

HOW COMMUNITIES WON

Stopping ICE Warehouses: A Tactical Guide

Five communities have stopped ICE detention warehouses. Here's exactly how they did it — and how yours can too.

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WAREHOUSES IDENTIFIED

CASE STUDY

Minnesota: Community Pressure Forces Property Owner Out

What happened: In early 2026, news broke that an ICE contractor was negotiating to lease a warehouse in the Minneapolis suburbs for a detention facility. Within days, community members organized protests at the site.

How they won:

- Neighbors identified the property owner and organized direct outreach campaigns
- Community groups flooded city council meetings with public comments opposing the facility
- Local media coverage amplified the story, putting pressure on elected officials
- The property owner publicly backed out of the deal, citing community opposition

KEY TACTIC: Property Owner Pressure

The property owner is often the weakest link. They're local business people who don't want to be known as the person who brought a concentration camp to town. Direct, sustained, public pressure works.

CASE STUDY

Missouri: County Passes 5-Year Moratorium

What happened: A county legislator personally investigated a warehouse site after receiving tips from constituents. The investigation revealed that ICE contractors had been negotiating in secret.

How they won:

- A single county legislator took the lead, conducting site visits and gathering documentation
- The legislator introduced emergency legislation for a five-year moratorium on detention facilities
- Community members packed the hearing, providing testimony about public safety and infrastructure concerns
- The moratorium passed, creating a legal barrier that blocked ICE from proceeding

KEY TACTIC: Legislative Moratorium

A moratorium creates a legal wall. Even if the federal government pushes back, a local moratorium buys time and shifts the burden of proof. Ask your county or city council to introduce emergency legislation.

CASE STUDY

Virginia: Unanimous Board of Supervisors Resolution

What happened: Community members discovered that an ICE contractor was pursuing a warehouse lease in their county. They immediately organized.

How they won:

- Residents organized a rapid-response campaign targeting the Board of Supervisors
- The Board passed a **unanimous** resolution opposing the facility — bipartisan, no dissent
- The resolution gave the property owner political cover to back out of negotiations
- The deal was killed within weeks of the community learning about it

KEY TACTIC: Bipartisan Resolution

ICE warehouses are not a partisan issue at the local level. Republican and Democratic supervisors alike don't want secret federal facilities overwhelming their infrastructure. Frame it as a local sovereignty issue.

CASE STUDY

Utah: Mayor Leads Community Opposition

What happened: ICE contractors approached a property owner about converting a warehouse. The mayor got involved early.

How they won:

- The mayor publicly opposed the facility and organized direct outreach to the property owner
- Community members joined the pressure campaign with petitions and public statements
- The property owner publicly refused to sell or lease to ICE contractors

KEY TACTIC: Executive Leadership

When a mayor or county executive takes a public stand early, it dramatically accelerates the timeline. Get to your mayor first — they have the most to lose from a facility that overwhelms local services.

PATTERNS OF SUCCESS

What Every Winning Community Did

- 1. Speed.** Every successful campaign moved fast. The window between discovery and a signed lease can be weeks. Don't wait for perfect information — organize the moment you hear about a potential site.
- 2. Property owner pressure.** Four out of five wins came from pressuring the property owner directly. They are private citizens making a business decision — they can change their minds.
- 3. Local government engagement.** Whether it's a moratorium, a resolution, or a mayor taking a stand, official government opposition creates legal and political barriers that ICE cannot easily bypass.
- 4. Infrastructure arguments.** The strongest arguments at city council aren't about immigration policy — they're about sewage capacity, water supply, traffic, emergency services, and property values. A warehouse designed for 50 daytime workers cannot support 1,500 to 10,000 residents 24/7.
- 5. Media coverage.** Every successful campaign generated significant local media coverage. Reporters are interested in this story. Call them.

Every warehouse stopped so far was stopped by people like you. The federal government is powerful, but it cannot build a facility over the objections of an entire community. Organize, move fast, and don't stop.